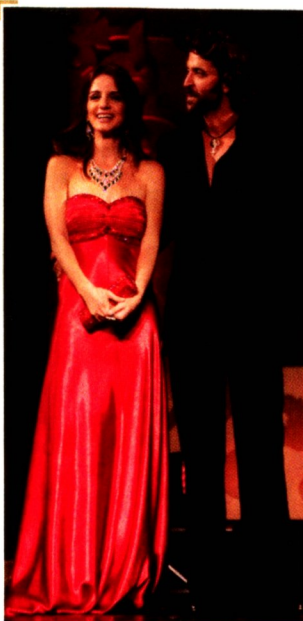


Couple Capers



Abhishek Bachchan and Aishwarya Rai Bachchan
The two couldn't get enough of each other. Abhishek shone in his suits while Aishwarya continued her lacklustre tryst with clothes.



Hrithik and Sussanne Roshan
They were always together. But they disappointed when it came to fashion. Thumbs down to Sussanne's red gown and Hrithik's stubble.



Arjun Rampal and Mehr Jesia
The actor loves his wife. The two handled their daughters deftly. Coordinated in black, Jesia shed a tear when Rampal won Supporting Actor.



Ashutosh and Sunita Gowariker
Sunita's sharp style sense always takes centrestage. Ashutosh says she's the business brain. No wonder he can't thank her enough.

the madding crowd, Sushmita Sen chose to stick to the high rollers area, where commoners aren't allowed and minimum bets start at HK \$5,000. Sen settled for a table where bets were going for upwards of HK \$30,000, but considering that she's luckier in love, the actor lost it all.

Outside the casino though, the mood wasn't upbeat. Most stars, including Shah Rukh Khan, Salman Khan, Akshay Kumar and Twinkle Khanna, Saif Ali Khan and Kareena Kapoor, Ranbir Kapoor and Deepika Padukone, had skipped the event. Priyanka Chopra arrived only on the last day. Shahid Kapoor cancelled his performance at the last minute because he allegedly hadn't been given details of the stage set-up or the music on time. As brand ambassador of the event, Amitabh Bachchan was omnipresent. From attending press conferences to handing the Global Leadership Awards to giving away the

Lifetime Achievement Award to Rajesh Khanna, he did it all. He obliged all with interviews. Is it any wonder that he got The Venetian's royal treatment at the exclusive Palazzo suite meant only for vips. The suite has a swimming pool, three bedrooms, a massage room and is all of 6,000 sq ft.

Though low on star power, the IIFA Awards weren't short on enthusiastic onlookers. After all it was the 10th year. In the past, the show has travelled to Bangkok, Amsterdam and Yorkshire to popularise Hindi films and the packed auditorium in Macau was a throwback to that time. Of course, once Boman Irani and Riteish Deshmukh started their gag-a-thon, the cheer returned. The show went on for six hours, but not without hiccups. The first one came when Shah Rukh Khan was announced Actor of the Decade. For an awkward two minutes, no one claimed the trophy. Even Bachchan Senior looked confused. To

make matters worse, when presenter Madhur Bhandarkar called Priyanka Chopra to collect it, she blurted, "This makes absolutely no sense."

People shifted in their seats once again when Anil Kapoor was asked to present Aishwarya Rai Bachchan with the Actress of the Decade honour. Irani had spoofed Kapoor in *Slumdog Millionaire* by bellowing, "Fantastic, fabulous, mind blowing, mind blasting... *chaiwala* (a reference to Dev Patel's character)." Kapoor was not impressed and as soon as Aishwarya stepped on stage, he said, "Fantastic, mind blowing... *chaiwali*." Aishwarya, perfect smile in place, quipped, "Thank you... *chaiwala*." The tension on stage travelled to the last row. The night finally ended with the privileged few heading to Bachchan Junior's suite for an after party. Bidding Macau adieu, Lara Dutta summed it up, "We all may have lost at the tables, but we sure won their hearts." ■